Mock Interview Edition

Customer-Support Agents: Supervisors, Validators and the Cost of a Wrong Block

16 scenarios with their follow-up probes and no answers. Use it to rehearse aloud, with a partner, or against a timer, then check yourself against the Study Edition.

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HOW THIS EDITION IS ORGANIZED

Section A, round plans: 5 ready-made sessions of five scenarios each, by theme. **Section B, question sheets:** every scenario followed by all of its probes, in order, each with its own notes box. The Study Edition page that holds the answers is printed under each scenario. **Section C, score sheet:** one row per scenario to track attempts. Question numbers and part numbers are identical in the Study Edition.

THREE WAYS TO USE IT

1. With a partner. The partner reads the scenario aloud, then asks the probes one at a time, moving on only after you have answered. **2. Alone, out loud.** Cover everything below the current probe with a sheet of paper, answer aloud for about two minutes, then slide the paper down to the next probe. **3. Alone, in writing.** Jot your key points in the notes box under each probe before looking at the next one, then compare with the Study Edition page printed under the scenario.

HOW TO GRADE A PROBE

Solid: you stated the main point, gave a number or a concrete example where one was possible, and said how you would check it. **Partial:** right direction but vague, or a number without the reasoning. **Missed:** you did not reach it, or reached the wrong conclusion. The last probe of every scenario asks for the general lesson in one sentence. Suggested pacing is about 12 minutes per scenario. Reading the answer only after you have committed to your own is what makes the practice work.

A NOTE ON THE PACING, GRADING AND ROUNDS

The 12-minute pacing, the three-level grading and the round compositions are the author's suggestions for practice, not an industry standard. The scenarios are written for this document and are not taken from a real company question bank. Where a scenario quotes a figure, the Study Edition says where it comes from.

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Every line below is a link: click it to jump to that page. The outline panel of your PDF viewer lists the same entries, and the “Contents” link in every page footer brings you back here. Question numbers are the same as in the Study Edition.

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Every scenario, by part

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SECTION A

Round plans

Each round has five scenarios at about 12 minutes each, a 60-minute session. Mix and match freely. Click any scenario to jump to its question sheet; the number on the right is the page.

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11 Does the validator pay for itself? Economics 18
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SECTION B

Question sheets

Each scenario is followed by its probes in order. Indentation shows how deep the follow-up goes.

PART 1

Framing the problem: two cases, outcome against correctness, and the sizing

Keeping a vendor's design apart from a company's results, asking what a month-one metric proves, and checking a company's figures against each other.

01 One system, or two cases?

SOURCES

SCENARIO

A colleague presents Sierra's supervisor architecture and Klarna's 2.3 million conversations as one deployment: Sierra's design, running at Klarna. Check what the sources say.

OPENING PROBE

What does Klarna's release say?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What do Sierra's posts say about Klarna?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

So what can you say?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What would you do in a presentation?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 6

02 What does month one prove?

EVALUATION

SCENARIO

Klarna's release says its assistant handled two-thirds of chats in its first month, resolved errands in under 2 minutes against 11, matched human satisfaction and cut repeat inquiries by 25%. A manager reads that as proof the system is correct. Press reports later describe a reversal. Say what the metrics show.

OPENING PROBE

Which are outcome metrics?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

Which is closest to correctness?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What was reported later?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What does that teach?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 7

03 Size the sessions

ESTIMATION

SCENARIO

Klarna says 2.3 million conversations were two-thirds of its customer service chats in the first month, and that customers resolve errands in under 2 minutes. Estimate total volume and concurrent sessions, and say what the numbers are bounds on.

OPENING PROBE

What is the total volume?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What is the arrival rate?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

How many sessions at once?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What is the peak?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 8

04 Check the 700 agents

ESTIMATION

SCENARIO

Klarna says its assistant does the equivalent work of 700 full-time agents and that resolution took 11 minutes before. A reviewer asks whether those two figures are consistent with 2.3 million conversations.

OPENING PROBE

What if every conversation took 11 minutes of agent time?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What does 700 imply?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

How can both be true?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What should you do with them?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 9

PART 2

Data and consistency: customer memory, policy and a refund that happens twice

What unifying customer data buys, how stale policy turns into wrong actions, and how a check-then-act race refunds twice.

05 What does a unified customer record give an agent?

DATA

SCENARIO

A team proposes giving the agent access to each backend system separately, one tool per system. Sierra describes a unified layer. Compare, using Sierra's November post.

OPENING PROBE

What does Sierra describe?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What can an agent do with it?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What does separate tooling lose?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What does unifying cost?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 10

06 A refund and the very next message

CONSISTENCY

SCENARIO

A customer asks for a refund and the agent processes it. Seconds later the customer writes, did my refund go through? A lagging read could show the order as not yet refunded. Work out what can go wrong, and what to require.

OPENING PROBE

What is the risk?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

Show a timeline.

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What should the design require?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What else protects it?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 11

07 The policy changed an hour ago

POLICY

SCENARIO

Refund policy changes at 10:00. The agents read a cached copy of the policy that refreshes every hour. A manager says an hour's delay is harmless. Size it.

OPENING PROBE

How many actions in an hour?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

How many does the change touch?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

Is that harmless?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What are the options?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 12

08 Review the refund executor

CODE REVIEW

SCENARIO

A colleague writes the executor below. In production, some customers are refunded twice, mostly when they send two messages quickly or when a retry follows a timeout. Find the faults.

```
def execute_refund(order_id, amount):
    order = db.get(order_id)
    if order["last_action"] is None:
        payments.refund(order_id, amount)
        order["last_action"] = "refund"
        db.put(order_id, order)
```

OPENING PROBE

What is the race?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What about a crash?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What does the payment call lack?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

State the fix.

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 13

PART 3

Agent design: supervisors, validators, bounded errors and what a check costs

What Sierra's supervisors actually do, why a check should be separate, how to set tolerance by kind of instruction, and the cost of a validator that blocks good actions.

09 What do Sierra's supervisors do?

ARCHITECTURE

SCENARIO

A teammate draws Sierra's design as a router that sends each request to a domain specialist, with a validator behind it. Compare the drawing with what Sierra's posts say.

OPENING PROBE

What are the supervisors?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What do they do?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What is the constellation?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

How does the drawing differ?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 14

10 Why a separate check?

DESIGN

SCENARIO

A specialist agent can be told, check your answer before sending. A reviewer asks why you pay for a second call by a separate validator. Argue it, and say what the second call cannot do.

OPENING PROBE

What does a self-check share?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What does a separate call change?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What can it not do?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What does it cost?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 15

11 Does the validator pay for itself?

ECONOMICS

SCENARIO

An analyst says: the validator costs 37 dollars a day and prevents 4,140 dollars of bad actions, a 112 times return. Recompute it with the false alarms the analyst left out. All rates are assumptions.

OPENING PROBE

What are the inputs?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 5

What is the analyst's number?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 5

What did it leave out?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 5

What is the corrected result?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 5

How sensitive is it?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 5 OF 5

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 16

12 Which instructions get which mechanism?

POLICY

SCENARIO

Sierra's October post sorts instructions by tolerance. Your team has four rules: refuse a prompt injection, never reveal another customer's data, collect an order number before a return, and be warm in tone. Assign a mechanism to each, and compute why the strict ones need layers.

OPENING PROBE

What are the buckets?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

Assign the four rules.

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

Why layers?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What does bounded mean?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 17

PART 4

Serving, evaluation and operations

Checking before or after acting, availability of a chain, auditing a validator, and what grows at ten times the volume.

13 Check before the action, or after?

SERVING

SCENARIO

A product owner wants the validator to run after the refund is sent, to save its latency. Sierra's supervisors have an observe mode and an intercept mode. Decide, and show the latency and the risk.

OPENING PROBE

What does the check cost in time?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What does an after-the-fact check do?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What does Sierra describe?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What would you do?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 18

14 The availability of a chain

RELIABILITY

SCENARIO

The design chains a supervisor, a specialist and a validator. Each is 99.9% available. A manager asks what the platform's availability is, and how Sierra's provider failover fits.

OPENING PROBE

What is the chain's availability?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What does redundancy do?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What does Sierra describe?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What is the catch in failover?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 19

15 Audit what the validator approved

MONITORING

SCENARIO

Nobody can read every approved action. The team wants an estimate of the validator's catch rate. Work out why a random audit does not give one and what to do instead.

OPENING PROBE

How rare are the bad approved actions?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What does a random audit need?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What do you do instead?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What else should you track?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 20

16 Risks, and ten times the volume

RISK

SCENARIO

A launch review asks what can go wrong with a support agent platform and what grows at ten times Klarna's first-month volume. Use the sources and the earlier arithmetic.

OPENING PROBE

What are the risks?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 1 OF 4

What does ten times do to sessions?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 2 OF 4

What does it do to cost?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 3 OF 4

What does it do to audit?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

FOLLOW-UP 4 OF 4

Reframe it: what is the general lesson, in one sentence?

YOUR NOTES: key points you would make

Answers: Study Edition, page 21

SECTION C

Score sheet

Write how many probes were solid out of the total, per attempt. Revisit anything under half after reading the Study Edition's concepts box.

No.	Scenario	Probes	Attempt 1	Attempt 2	Attempt 3
01	One system, or two cases?	5			
02	What does month one prove?	5			
03	Size the sessions	5			
04	Check the 700 agents	5			
05	What does a unified customer record give an agent?	5			
06	A refund and the very next message	5			
07	The policy changed an hour ago	5			
08	Review the refund executor	5			
09	What do Sierra's supervisors do?	5			
10	Why a separate check?	5			
11	Does the validator pay for itself?	6			
12	Which instructions get which mechanism?	5			
13	Check before the action, or after?	5			
14	The availability of a chain	5			
15	Audit what the validator approved	5			
16	Risks, and ten times the volume	5			